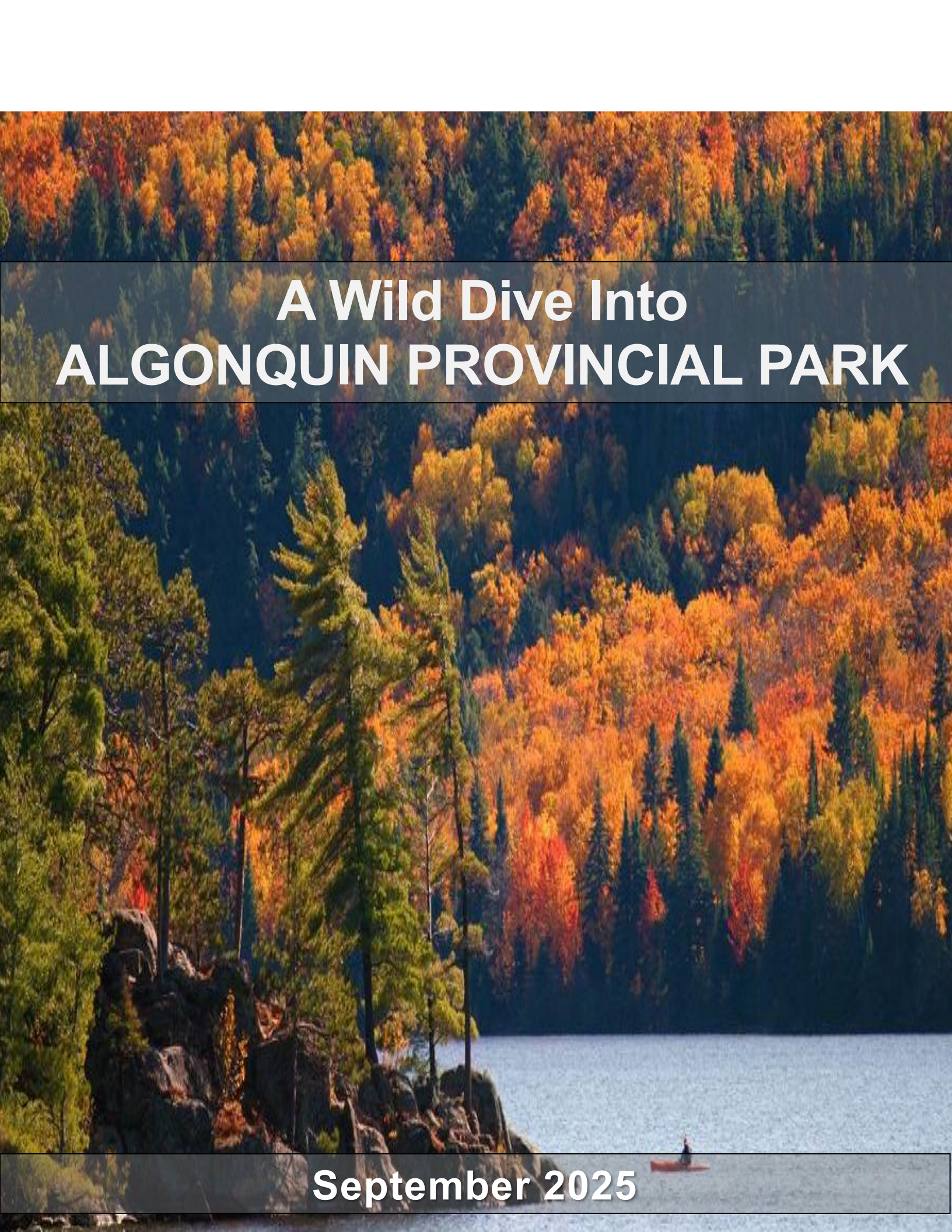




A Wild Dive Into ALGONQUIN PROVINCIAL PARK

September 2025

Preface

This report is prepared within the framework of the project “The Wild Dives- First Descent Geographic Expeditions” implemented by NYGEP COHORT 10 in collaboration with Toronto and Region Conservation Authority team. The main goal of this report is to highlight the importance of freshwater ecosystems in Algonquin Provincial and assess the ecological status and conservation efforts.

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I. General information

1.1 Classification and legal status

Algonquin Provincial Park, established in 1893 as Ontario's first provincial park, covers approximately 772,300 hectares of diverse landscapes (Ontario Ministry of Natural Resources, 1998, 2006). It is Classified as a Natural Environment Park according to the Provincial Parks and Conservation Reserves Act, 2006 (PPCRA) and it protects a diverse array of natural, cultural, and recreational values, including more than 1,000 vascular plant species and over 200 breeding vertebrates alongside intact aquatic ecosystems and representative forest types of the Canadian Shield (Ontario Ministry of Natural Resources, 1998, 2013a) .

Algonquin is also culturally significant: it has inspired generations of artists, researchers, and writers, and contains important archaeological and historical resources that reflect both Indigenous and settler histories (Ontario Ministry of Natural Resources, 1998).

Internationally, the park is recognized as a National Park Equivalent, broadly corresponding to the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) Category II designation, which emphasizes the conservation of ecosystems while allowing compatible recreation (Dudley, 2008). The park plays a dual role as both a conservation landscape and a major recreational destination attracting over 800,000 visitors annually, making it one of Canada's most iconic protected areas (Eagles, 2014)

Land use and resource activities in Algonquin are shaped by provincial legislation and long-term planning documents, such as the *Algonquin Provincial Park Management Plan* and *Ontario's Living Legacy Land Use Strategy* (Ontario Ministry of Natural Resources, 2006, 2013a). Forestry is managed by the Algonquin Forestry Authority, working under plans developed with input from First Nations and Métis communities. Current frameworks include the *2020–2031 Strategic Plan* and the *2025–2026 Annual Work Schedule*, which together guide operations as part of the park's broader Forest Management Plan (Algonquin Forestry Authority, 2025)

1.2 Location, History, Indigenous communities

Algonquin Park is located between Georgian Bay and the Ottawa River in south-central Ontario. The Park lies within the area bounded by Highway 11, Highway 62, and the Trans Canada Highway (Highway 17). Highway 60 crosses the southern part of Algonquin over a distance of 63 kilometres. Most Park facilities are concentrated along this corridor. The Park is surrounded by the communities of Pembroke, North Bay, Huntsville, and Bancroft and a variety of provincial parks, including Samuel de Champlain, Restoule, Mikisew, Arrowhead, Bonnechere, and Driftwood. Four Waterway Provincial Parks border Algonquin with their head waters protected within the Park: Bonnechere,

Upper Madawaska, Opeongo, and Ox-tongue Rivers. Algonquin Provincial Park is situated on the flanks and summit of a dome of Precambrian Canadian Shield bed rock with elevations reaching 587 metres above sea level on the west side to 150 metres on the east side of the Park. Five major rivers drain the Park: the Oxtongue, Petawawa, Barron, Madawaska, and Bonnechere (Ontario Ministry of Natural Resources, 1998).

For much of its past, the area saw only small, seasonal visits from Indigenous peoples, who came to fish, hunt, and gather berries, with little in the way of permanent settlement. Significant change arrived in the 1800s, when pioneer loggers from the Ottawa Valley moved into the highlands in search of white pine, prized in the British market. Working from remote camps, they felled and squared the timber, sending it downstream each spring. The park's formal establishment in 1893 was aimed not at ending logging, but at creating a wildlife sanctuary and safeguarding the headwaters of five major rivers by excluding agricultural development. In the decades that followed, anglers, artists such as Tom Thomson and the Group of Seven, and tourists arriving by train added new layers to the park's cultural story, shaping the blend of natural and human heritage that continues to define it today. (The Friends of Algonquin Park, n.d.)

Algonquin Park lies within the area subject to the Algonquin land claim, which seeks to resolve longstanding Indigenous title and treaty issues relevant to the Algonquin of Ontario (AOO). The land claim process underscores contemporary Indigenous claims to lands, rights, and title, which influence co-management, consultation, and planning regimes in and around the park (Government of Ontario, 2024)

II. Management

2.1 Management objectives

2.2 Management bodies

2.3 Zoning

2.4 Stakeholders map

III. Biodiversity

3.1 Land

3.1.1 Habitats

3.1.2 Flora

3.1.3 Fauna

3.2 Water

3.2.1 Habitats

3.2.2 Flora

3.2.3 Fauna

**For 3.1 and 3.2 Please mention if there are endemic species or species/habitats of high importance

IV. Attractions and Recreational activities

4.1 Hikes

4.2 Cottages

4.3 Canoe

4.4 Archeological values

V. Pressures and Risks

5.1 Climate change

5.2 Invasive species

5.3 Dams

5.4 Development

Development pressures in Algonquin Provincial Park include cottage lot tenure and forestry operations, both of which pose risks to ecological values. As of 2018, there were 303 private, non-commercial cottage lots (326 cottages) distributed across 22 lakes in several sub-watersheds, with approximately 90% concentrated along the Highway 60 corridor, particularly in two quaternary sub-watersheds (Ontario Parks, 2018). These cottage lots occupy about 131 hectares and include roughly 26 km of shoreline (Ontario Ministry of Natural Resources, 2013b; Ontario Parks, 2018). Under the Algonquin Provincial Park Cottage Lot Policy (2018–2038), cottage occupants may extend their tenure until December 31, 2038, subject to conditions designed to reduce ecological

impacts such as shoreline disturbance, sewage management, and the use of fertilizers or pesticides, while ensuring compliance with relevant legislation (Ontario Parks, 2018).

Forestry operations represent another source of pressure. In 2022–2023, the Algonquin Forestry Authority (AFA) operated under the 2021–2031 Forest Management Plan, which sets sustainable harvest targets and monitoring frameworks (Algonquin Forestry Authority, 2023). The sustainable harvest limit is approximately 710,622 cubic metres per year; however, actual harvest volumes have been lower in recent years, averaging about 380,000 m³ over the past five years, largely due to market constraints and other factors (Algonquin Forestry Authority, 2023). Forestry operations are subject to independent audits and certification standards, most recently under the Sustainable Forestry Initiative (SFI) in 2023, along with guidelines intended to protect recreation, wildlife habitat, fisheries, and cultural and natural heritage values (Algonquin Forestry Authority, 2023).

5.5 Anthropogenic impacts

VI. Monitoring and conservation

6.1 Water quality monitoring

6.2 Species monitoring

6.3 Invasive species monitoring

**For 6.2 and 6.3 focus more in freshwater ecosystems

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